Kumi and other Chin ethnic groups were already living in the region[17] and continued to do so in the remote hilly regions.

The nineteenth-century British historian H.H. Wilson suggested that the dominant culture in Arakan was Indian up to the tenth century AD, and that only then did growing interaction with Burmese culture begin.[18] Pamela Gutman[19] follows Wilson in arguing that the only way to understand the history of Arakan up to this point is to see it as a region of India rather than part of the Burmese world. In particular, the high coastal mountains and difficult terrain made overland interaction with the rest of contemporary Myanmar much harder than forging links across the Bay of Bengal.

Gutman suggests that whoever was in Arakan before the ninth century AD had ethnic links to Indian groups, rather than to groups in what is today Myanmar. The Rohingyas, whose language is Indo–Aryan,[20] from the Bengali–Assamese branch, may well descend from these pre-ninth-century inhabitants of the region, whereas the Rakhine did not arrive until the ninth century. The Indo–Aryan roots of the Rohingyas are manifested in inscriptions from the Hindu temples at Anandra Chandra (eighth century AD), which display close similarities to similar inscriptions and buildings in India.[21]

The earliest rulers of Arakan were mostly Hindus,[22] reflecting the links to India. However, Islam arrived in the seventh century via trading links to India and Arabia, but the region remained multi-confessional, with Hindus, Buddhists and Muslims living together.[23] Under these influences, the Rohingyas' language evolved from its early roots with the adoption of Arabic and Persian words, and the script adapted to more closely resemble that of Bengali. Equally, as an ethnic group, the Rohingyas absorbed Arab and Persian elements in the period up to 1000 AD. Later, the close links with Bengal meant absorbing both Bengali and Mughal ethnic influences as part of the regular interaction with northern India.

As Burmese power consolidated in the central Irrawaddy region, the degree of interaction between Arakan and the Burmese kingdoms increased. The Rakhine ethnic group crossed the Arakan Mountains and settled in the region in around 1000 AD, and this was followed by a period of relative domination of the region by the Burmese Pagan Kingdom. In effect, from 1000 AD Arakan came to interact as much with the rest of Burma as it did with Bengal and northern India.